2.1 Hardship and Weapons

Siblings fight over all kinds of things: household chores, toys, television programs. During the Civil War, however, some siblings argued over a much larger issue: whether to support the Union or the Confederacy.

MAIN IDEA Soldiers in the Civil War faced difficulties at home and in the field, including dealing with technological advances on the front lines.

A SOLDIER'S LIFE

The Civil War divided not only a nation but also families. Siblings, parents, and even spouses sometimes found themselves on different sides of the debate. It was not uncommon to hear of two brothers serving in opposing armies. No one was spared from these divisions, not even Abraham Lincoln. His brother-in-law, Ben Hardin Helm, was a Confederate general.

Whichever side the soldiers served on, life was difficult and dangerous. For every 30 days in the field, the average soldier engaged in battle one day and drilled, trained, and marched the remaining 29. Army leaders had difficulty keeping track of their units' needs, so supplies didn't always arrive when required. The soldiers were often cold and hungry as a result. Disease killed more men than fighting did.

And now army leaders had more soldiers under their command. After Bull Run, both the Confederate and Union leaders realized they needed larger armies. Farmers under the age of 30 made up about half of the men on both sides. Some older men joined the ranks as well, and boys as young as 12 served as drummers and buglers. About a quarter of the Union volunteers were young immigrants, mainly from Germany, Ireland, Canada, and England. Another group of people, African-American men, could have been drafted into fighting, but it would be several years before either army began to recruit them or even allow them to enlist.



Wooden Legs, Iron Arms
Approximately 70,000 soldiers lost limbs during the battles of the Civil War. The government offered veterans money to buy prosthetic, or artificial, arms, feet, and legs, like this one, to replace their missing limbs. Many options made of wood, iron, and leather were soon available. Few, however, were comfortable or functional. Most soldiers chose to use crutches and hooks instead.

A NEW KIND OF WAR

The Civil War battlefield was far more dangerous than it had been in previous American wars. Advances in technology made fighting more efficient and deadlier than ever. In earlier wars, soldiers carried muskets, which were not very accurate. The inside of a musket's barrel was polished smooth, causing the bullet's flight to be unpredictable. And a man fighting on the battlefield with a musket had to stand within 80 yards of his enemy in order to hit him. All that changed in the 1850s when a new kind of rifle replaced the musket. The grooves carved inside the barrel made the bullet spin as it hurtled toward its target. The spinning made the bullet fly in a straighter line and gave it a greater range—more than 1,000 yards.

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CRITICAL VIEWING As this 1862 photograph of the Union Army reveals, Civil War soldiers used heavy guns and fought from trenches. What might have been some of the disadvantages of fighting and living in trenches such as these?



Some Union soldiers had another technological advantage in their hands: the repeating rifle. Instead of having to reload a gun after each shot, a soldier armed with a repeating rifle could fire several times before having to replenish his ammunition. These technological advances would continue to be improved and affect how future wars were fought.

With improvements to both rifles and larger cannons, soldiers increasingly resorted to **trench warfare** during the Civil War. Opposing armies dug lines of trenches, or ditches, roughly parallel to each other. The trenches gave soldiers both a vantage point from which to fire and a place to shelter from incoming rounds of ammunition. Advances in naval technology also brought changes to warfare at sea. Before, ordinary wooden ships were vulnerable to cannon and rifle fire. New **ironclad ships**, or ships plated with thick metal, could withstand this heavy artillery.

Unfortunately, the technology of medical treatment had not transformed as fast as the technology of war. Effective treatments for infections, such as antibiotics, had not yet been invented. **Mortality**, or the death rate, from wounds and disease was high. And the hundreds of thousands of sick and wounded required medical attention, which in turn created a shortage of people to care for them. Hard-working male doctors and nurses set up hospitals in makeshift buildings and did their best to treat the soldiers, but they struggled to keep up with the flood of patients. The acute need for more caregivers was soon answered, however. Large numbers of women volunteered to provide much-needed care as nurses and administrators.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What sort of struggles did Civil War soldiers face before they arrived on the battlefield?
2. **DETERMINE WORD MEANING** What context clues help you understand what *replenish* means?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** What impact do you think technological advances had on the soldiers' mortality rate?

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